



the basic
idea

does free
will explain
any evil?

A large, solid orange circle with a subtle drop shadow, centered on a white background. Inside the circle, the text "does free will explain all evil?" is written in white, lowercase, sans-serif font, arranged in three lines.

does free
will explain
all evil?

1. Some instance of rape, torture, murder, or child abuse is a great evil
 2. There is no good which outweighs this event and which is such that an omnipotent being could not have brought about the good without the tsunami.
 3. A perfectly good being would eliminate every evil unless there was a good which outweighed that evil and it was impossible for that being to eliminate the evil without eliminating the good.
 4. There is no omnipotent and perfectly good being. (1,2,3)
 5. If there is no omnipotent and perfectly good being, God does not exist.
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C. God does not exist. (4,5)

“Traditional free-will approaches - with their move to shift responsibility and/or blame for evil away from God and onto personal creatures - are stalemated by horrendous evil. Human radical vulnerability to horrors cannot have its origin in misused created freedom, because - even if one accepted the story of Adam’s fall as historical (which I do not) - the way it is told, humans were radically vulnerable to horrors from the beginning, even in Eden. The framework within which the primal ancestors made their choices was such that obedient choices meant persistence of the status quo, while disobedient choices would result in the horrendous disarray such as humans have experienced ever since. Even if Adam’s and Eve’s choices are supposed to be somehow self-determined, the fact that the consequences amplify far beyond their capacity to conceive and hence to intend - viz., to horrors of which ex hypothesi they had no prior experience and of which they could therefore have no adequate conception - is not something for which humans are responsible. Rather it is a function of the interaction between human agency and the wider framework within which it is set, and God is responsible for creating human beings in such a framework!”

Surely many events such as these occurred before human beings were on the scene; and surely at least some animal suffering of this kind is an evil.

This gives us the resources to construct a new argument:

The argument from horrific evils

We have now laid out three arguments based, not on the existence of some evil in the world, but based on the existence of particular evils: the evil caused by natural disasters, the evil of pre-human suffering, and especially horrific evils.

2. There is no good which outweighs this event and which is such that an omnipotent being could not have brought about the good without the evil.

3. A perfectly good being would eliminate every evil unless there was a good which outweighed that evil and it was impossible for that being to eliminate the evil without eliminating the good.

Each of these arguments relies on the following premises:

Let's briefly look at some ways in which one might object to these premises.



eliminating the good.

does not exist.

5 If there is no merit and perfectly good being, God

there was a good weight and it was

impossible for that being to eliminate the evil without

about the good without the strain.

Some instances of rape, torture, murder, or child abuse is a

c. God does not exist. (4,5)

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3. Perfectly good being would eliminate every evil

2. There is no good without weight and which is

4. There is no omnipotent and perfectly good being. (1, 2, 3)

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suffering of this kind is evil.

beings were on the scene; and surely at least some animal

Surely many events such as the current before human

suffering, and especially horrific evils.

of some evil in the world, but based on the existence of particular

We have now laid out the arguments based, not on the existence

evil: the evil caused by natural disasters, the evil of pre-human



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3. Perfectly good being would

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eliminate every evil

Let's briefly look at some ways in which one might object to these

premises.

**Free will
cannot
explain any
evil.**

Free will can explain some evil; but it can't explain all of the evil we find in the world.

does free
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any evil?

does free
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God. It can explain that, it seems, if we make the following assumption:

Summing up so far: we have seen that Frege will promise to explain how

there could be evil in a world with a omnipotent and perfectly good

there are possible
situations which an
omnipotent
being cannot
bring about



we have
free will



free will is
a great good

the ability
to harm others
is a great good



tsuririri.

2. There is no god which

is what that argument

outweighs this event and which

being or would not have brought

about the good with the





of some evil in the world, but based on the existence of particular

evils: the evils caused by natural disasters, the evil of pre-human

suffering, and especially horrific evils.

We have now laid out three arguments based, not on the existence

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eliminating the good.

3. Perfectly good being world

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eliminate every evil

Each of these arguments relies on the following premise: